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Strangers in a Strange Land

Japanese Castaways and the Opening of Japan

Stephen W. Kohl



Historical accounts of Commodore Matthew Perry's 1854 visit to Japan generally note that the Japanese interpreters could speak English. Usually a footnote explains that they learned English from American castaway sailors who ended up in Japan. If we pursue the question of who these Americans were, we soon come upon the remarkable story of Ranald MacDonald, who in 1848 surreptitiously entered Japan, was captured and imprisoned there, and later rescued. Born in Astoria, Oregon Territory, MacDonald met three Japanese castaways at Fort Vancouver in the 1830s. As one writer pointed out, "It is believed by some that Ranald MacDonald's boyhood and early interest in forbidden Japan came from his association with the Japanese boys in the school of John Ball." But, having inspired young MacDonald, the sailors disappeared from history.¹

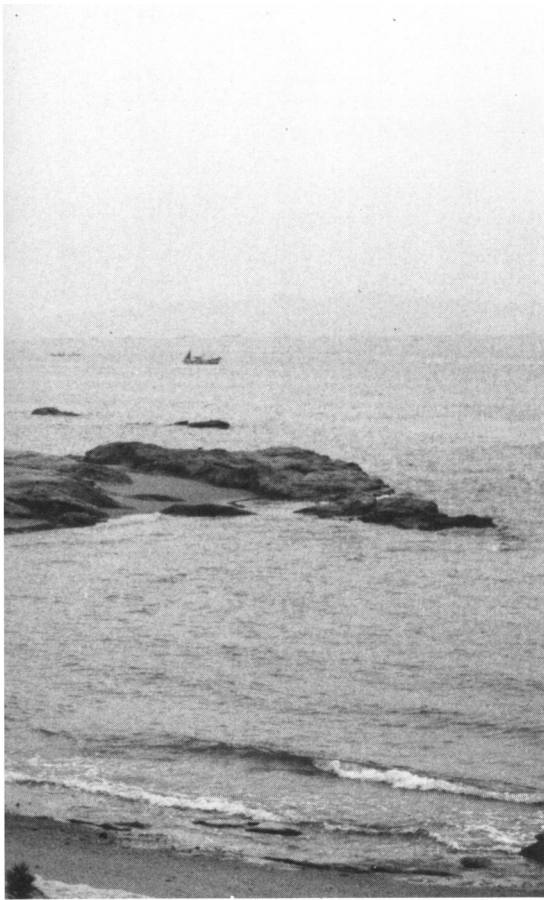
This paper takes up the story of the three castaways, their subsequent adventures, and most especially the important role they played in the process of opening Ja-

pan to foreign commerce both before and after Perry's historic visit. A combination of English and Japanese sources, which provide remarkably detailed information, permits us to restore the Japanese castaways to the historical record.²

In December 1832 the small Japanese coastal boat *Hyōjun Maru* set sail from

1. William S. Lewis and Naojiro Murakami, eds., *Ranald MacDonald* (Spokane, 1923); Eva Emery Dye, *McDonald of Oregon: A Tale of Two Shores*, 2d ed. (Chicago, 1907); Maria Leona Nichols, *Ranald MacDonald, Adventurer* (Caldwell, Idaho, 1940); Clifford M. Drury, "Early American Contacts with the Japanese," *PNQ*, Vol. 36 (1945), 319-30; Joel E. Ferris, "Ranald MacDonald, The Sailor Boy Who Visited Japan," *PNQ*, Vol. 48 (1957), 14 (quotation). Actually, it was the missionary Cyrus Shepard who taught the boys.

2. A most comprehensive and detailed study by Akira Haruna, *Nippon Otokichi hyōryūki* [An account of the castaway Otokichi of Japan] (Tokyo, 1979), provided the basis for my own study.



View from the village of Onoura. From Toba on the Ise Peninsula across the bay, the sailors began their ill-fated journey. (Author's collection)

Toba bound for Edo (Tokyo) with a load of rice and porcelain. In the treacherous waters of the Enshunada, a considerable distance from land, the craft encountered a storm. Losing both rudder and mast, it drifted for 13 or 14 months in the Pacific Ocean before washing ashore at Cape Flattery on the Olympic Peninsula. Presumably the sailors kept themselves alive by eating their cargo of rice and supplementing it with whatever fish they could catch. In any case, of 14 crew members, only the 3 youngest survived: Iwakichi was 28, Kyūkichī was 15, and Otokichi was 14.³

When the boat failed to arrive in Edo it was given up for lost. In the village of Onoura in the Owari domain, the home of most of the crew, funeral services were said and a gravestone was erected in the cemetery of the Ryōsanji Temple.⁴

On the other side of the Pacific, the three survivors faced new difficulties. Local Indians plundered their boat and enslaved them. Eventually news of the shipwreck and capture reached Fort Vancouver, where Dr. John McLoughlin, chief factor of the Hudson's Bay Company (HBC), set about getting them released. H. H. Bancroft recounted the matter this way:

One day in the spring of 1834 notice reached Fort Vancouver of the wreck of a junk off Cape Flattery. Thirty men under Thomas McKay were sent overland by way of the Chehalis to the rescue of the crew. But on reaching the precipitous region round Point Grenville they became disheartened, threw up the business, and retraced their steps. Captain McNeill then undertook the mission in the brig Llama. Arriving at the wreck, the Llama was boarded by some natives, whom the captain held as hostages until the survivors, three in number, were delivered to him. Brought to Fort Vancouver, the three men were sent home by way of England.⁵

During their several months' stay at Fort Vancouver, the castaways attended school. Then McLoughlin put them aboard the *Eagle* and sent them to London via Hawaii and Cape Horn at his own and the HBC's expense. In a letter to the company, he explained his action:

I might have sent them to Woahoo [Oahu] and left them to find a passage to their own country the best way they could, but as I believe they are the first Japanese who have been in the power of the British Nation I thought the British Government would gladly avail itself of this opportunity to endeavour to open a communication with the Japanese Government and that by these men going to Great Britain they would have an opportunity of being instructed and convey to their countrymen a respectable idea of the grandeur and power of the British nation. And even if this did not meet the views of the British Government I am certain from the well known philanthropy [sic] of the British people that individuals will be found who will do all that can be done to provide them with the means of returning to their native country, and though it may cause the Company some expense (though I believe in such cases the expense is defrayed by Government) still I faintly hope I have acted most consonant to your wishes.⁶

As it turned out, neither the HBC nor the British government thought much of McLoughlin's idea. British commercial policies in the Far East were in a state of considerable confusion at that time, and the government's first concern was to stabilize trade with China. England did not have time to worry about opening relations with Japan just then. And the

company criticized McLoughlin for the unnecessary expense he incurred by sending the castaways all the way to England.⁷

The Japanese arrived in England in June 1835 and spent 10 days on board their ship in the Thames, awaiting permission to land. But the government, having decided not to use them as a means of communicating with the Japanese government, determined to send them on to Macao and let them make their way back to Japan as best they could from there. On the day before they sailed for China, the castaways were allowed to go ashore and spend a day sightseeing in the streets of London. They were the first Japanese ever to set foot in England.

3. *Ibid.*, 29, 38. Since the Japanese government did not permit foreign commerce, it insured that Japanese boats would stay close to shore by making them unseaworthy in design. Any heavy sea would tear the rudder away, and in order to keep the boat into the wind so it would not capsize, the crew would have to cut the mast away. Once the storm cleared, however, the boat was crippled.

4. The stone still stands today with the names of all 14 crewmen engraved on it. Father Suzuki Kuniyoshi, the Zen priest at the temple, showed the author temple records from the 1830s listing the sailors as having perished.

5. Hubert H. Bancroft, *History of the Northwest Coast*, 2 vols. (San Francisco, 1884), II, 533; for a more laconic account, see E. E. Rich, ed., *The Letters of John McLoughlin from Fort Vancouver to the Governor and Committee*, First Series, 1825-38 (Toronto, 1941), 122 (letter of May 28, 1834). An earlier attempt was made from Nisqually House to rescue the sailors; see Clarence B. Bagley, ed., "Journal of Occurrences at Nisqually House," *WHQ*, Vol. 6 (1915), 276, and Vol. 7 (1916), 62.

6. Cyrus Shepard of the Methodist Mission of Oregon wrote on January 10, 1835, "I have also had three Japanese under instruction. . . . While in school, they were remarkably studious, and made very rapid improvement"; see "Early Letter from the Northwest Mission," *WHQ*, Vol. 24 (1933), 54. McLoughlin letter, Nov. 18, 1834, in Rich, 128.

7. Lord William Napier had been appointed superintendent of trade and was to supervise the dismantling of the East India Company monopoly; he had great difficulty in doing this and, when he died in 1834, left trade relations with China in considerable turmoil. W. G. Beasley, *Great Britain and the Opening of Japan, 1834-1858* (London, 1951), 21.